THE FAMILY LOYALISTS

Leaders who have remained steadfast with the Family. Only two of them are elected to LS/ state assembly



MANMOHAN SINGH, 89

Rajya Sabha member



A.K. ANTONY, 81

Rajya Sabha member



AMBIKA SONI, 79

Rajya Sabha member



P. CHIDAMBARAM, 76

Rajya Sabha member



MALLIKARJUN KHARGE, 79

Rajya Sabha member



PAWAN KUMAR BANSAL, 73

AICC treasurer, administration in-charge



ADHIR RANJAN CHOWDHURY, 65

CLP leader in Lok Sabha



SALMAN KHURSHID, 69

Permanent invitee to the CWC



D.K. SHIVAKUMAR, 59

MLA, president of Karnataka Congress Committee

REGIONAL SATRAPS

Veterans who are loyal to the Gandhis, but prone to doing their own thing in the states

ASHOK GEHLOT, 70

CM, Rajasthan



A member of the Core Group Committee, many see him as a potential non-Gandhi Congress president

BHUPESH BAGHEL, 60

CM, Chhattisgarh



Insiders say he refused to comply with Rahul Gandhi-brokered deal to quit the CM's position half way through term. Mobilised party resources for Assam, UP polls

KAMAL NATH, 75

Ex-CM, Madhya Pradesh



Focused on winning back MP now. Had brokered peace between G23 rebels and Sonia Gandhi in 2020

DIGVIJAYA SINGH, 75

Former Madhya Pradesh CM



RS member and permanent invitee to CWC, spends most of his time in MP

SIDDARAMAIAH, 73

Former CM, Karnataka



Confines himself to Karnataka affairs; the ex-socialist doesn't always follow the Congress narrative

When the Congress lost in four states in 2021, a five-member committee—which included G23 leader Manish Tewari— was constituted to examine the reasons for the defeat and suggest remedial measures. Tewari claims the reports were buried and no action was taken on the recommendations. Party MP from Tamil Nadu Manickam Tagore refutes this, saying the early formation of screening committees and early announcement of candidates in the past five assembly polls were due to these recommendations.

Upset with their increasing marginalisation, the G23 made their resentment official in a letter to Sonia in August 2020. Now reduced to G18, after the exit of nine members and entry of four new ones, they have reiterated their primary demands. If Kapil Sibal said that the Gandhis should step aside from leadership roles, another G18 leader, P.J. Kurien, believes Rahul should lead the Congress in Parliament and leave the post of president to others.

Rahul's inaccessibility was raised even by other stalwarts such as Digvijaya Singh, Mukul Wasnik and former Union minister K.H. Muniyappa (who are not part of G18) at the CWC meeting. Ghulam Nabi Azad, the unofficial head of G18, took a subtle dig at Rahul when he said the party needed a president who would be "accessible, acceptable and accountable". "The emphasis on accessible and accountable leadership is to indirectly dissuade Rahul from contesting the election to the post of president scheduled in September," says a CWC leader.

The party's central election authority (CEA), headed by Madhusudan Mistry, a known Rahul loyalist, has been supervising the organisational process. The electoral college for choosing the Congress president comprises the 10,000-plus PCC delegates elected at the block level by block presidents. This is the base on which the whole pyramid stands—the delegates elect the 1,400 AICC members from amongst themselves,